

Shared Ground

High Desert and the trusted-community network you described

FROM GREG CHISM · HIGH DESERT

John — when you described a private network for trustworthy people, built to keep value circulating among good actors and to optimize for value creation over extraction, you were describing the principle High Desert is already built on. A lot of what you’ve wanted to make for twenty years, I’ve spent the last stretch building a civic version of — and working through the hard parts. Here’s where the two line up, and where I think I could genuinely help.

WHERE IT ALREADY LINES UP

Value creation over extraction	→ The founding principle — no ads, no engagement ranking, member-owned data, surplus to the commons.
Keep money circulating among trusted people	→ A verified-resident local exchange — goods, services, skills — with no platform cut and no ads.
Buying & selling services	→ Tradespeople trade-for-trade and a needs exchange (“I have / I need”), on one listing primitive.
Barter & skill-trading	→ Non-monetary skill exchange, time-bank-flavored — deliberately before any currency.
Trustworthy membership	→ Multi-path, human-reviewed verification with verify-then-forget privacy.
Reviews	→ A completed-exchange “would do this again” signal — reputation as a fact, not a gameable score.
Handling untrustworthy members	→ Moderation with a written reason, an appeal, and a second reviewer — nothing vanishes silently.
Community self-determination	→ Tenure-weighted, secret-ballot governance; every decision reversible.
Values-driven structure	→ A member-governed nonprofit from day one — owned by no one, impossible to sell.
Events	→ A neighborhood event primitive with RSVPs, ordered by time and proximity, never popularity.

WHERE I THINK I CAN SAVE YOU PAIN

Reputation without the perception game.

Star ratings quietly become the thing people optimize instead of the relationship — the exact extraction you want to avoid. A mutual “this happened, I’d do it again,” tied to a real exchange, holds up far better.

Trust earned by behavior, alongside your read on personality.

Your strength is matching people by who they are; High Desert’s is establishing trust by what they do over time — verified membership, completed exchanges, tenure. Two complementary layers: compatibility by personality, trust earned by conduct.

Safety without collective punishment.

Banning whoever invited someone is fast, but unappealable, and it punishes the wrong person. A reasoned, appealable removal with a second reviewer buys the same safety without the arbitrariness.

A currency last, not first.

An in-app currency pulls in money—transmission law, tax, and speculation — how “value creation” quietly turns back into extraction. Start non-monetary; earn the right to a currency by a vote, later.

Bound trust, don’t scale it.

Tribal trust works because it’s small and high-context. The move is to keep cells small and verified — not to scale the trust itself.

WHAT I’D BRING

Working, documented primitives you could study or fork — **verified membership, the exchange, events, governance, moderation** — under an open license built for exactly this kind of replication. A design canon — a pattern language and a set of invariants — that has already argued through these trade-offs. And a second set of hands and eyes from someone who’s made the mistakes once already. I’d be glad to volunteer.